

Understanding the ‘curl’ Command: From Basics to Advanced Usage

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1 Introduction

The ‘curl’ command is a versatile tool for transferring data to or from a server using various protocols (e.g., HTTP, FTP, HTTPS). In Capture The Flag (CTF) challenges, it’s essential for testing web vulnerabilities, downloading files, or sending requests to APIs. This document covers ‘curl’ from basic usage to advanced techniques, with a focus on the example ‘curl -X POST http://10.10.183.179/api/items’.

2 Basic Concepts

- **Purpose**: ‘curl’ sends HTTP requests (GET, POST, etc.) or transfers files, mimicking a browser or client. - **Syntax**: ‘curl [options] <URL>’ - ‘[options]’: Flags to customize the request. - ‘<URL>’: Target (e.g., ‘http://example.com’). - **Default Behavior**: Without options, it performs a GET request and displays the response.

3 Getting Started: Basic Usage

3.1 Making a Simple GET Request

- Fetch a webpage:

```
1 curl http://10.10.183.179/
```

- Displays the raw HTML or response.

3.2 Saving Output to a File

- Download content to a file:

```
1 curl -o output.html http://10.10.183.179/
```

- ‘-o’: Specifies output file name.

3.3 Viewing Headers

- Include response headers:

```
1 curl -i http://10.10.183.179/
```

- '-i': Shows headers (e.g., 'HTTP/1.1 200 OK').

4 Intermediate Techniques

4.1 Sending a POST Request

- Use '-X' to specify the method, e.g., your example:

```
1 curl -X POST http://10.10.183.179/api/items
```

- ****Breakdown****: - '-X POST': Sets the request method to POST. - 'http://10.10.183.179/api/items': Targets the API endpoint. - ****Note****: Without data ('-data' or '-d'), this sends an empty POST, which might fail unless the API accepts it.

4.2 Adding Data to POST

- Send JSON or form data:

```
1 curl -X POST -d "item=fish" http://10.10.183.179/api/items
2 curl -X POST -H "Content-Type: application/json" -d '{"item": "fish"}' http://10.10.183.179/api/items
```

- '-d': Data payload. - '-H': Custom header (e.g., JSON content type).

4.3 Following Redirects

- Handle redirects automatically:

```
1 curl -L http://10.10.183.179/redirect
```

- '-L': Follows HTTP 3xx redirects.

5 Advanced Usage

5.1 Authentication

- Basic auth:

```
1 curl -u username:password http://10.10.183.179/api/items
```

- Bearer token:

```
1 curl -H "Authorization: Bearer token123" http://10.10.183.179/api/items
```

5.2 Verbose Output

- Debug with verbose mode:

```
1 curl -v http://10.10.183.179/api/items
```

- '-v': Shows request/response details.

5.3 Custom User-Agent

- Mimic a browser to avoid bans:

```
1 curl -A "Mozilla/5.0" http://10.10.183.179/
```

- '-A': Sets User-Agent.

5.4 Handling Cookies

- Send cookies:

```
1 curl -b "session=abc123" http://10.10.183.179/api/items
```

- '-b': Cookie string. - Save cookies:

```
1 curl -c cookies.txt http://10.10.183.179/
```

- '-c': Saves to a file.

6 Practical CTF Application

Your command 'curl -X POST http://10.10.183.179/api/items' is a start for the Pingu CTF. Let's enhance it: - **Add Data**: Pingu's fish key might need a payload:

```
1 curl -X POST -d "key=fish" http://10.10.183.179/api/items
```

- **Check Response**: Look for the key or flag:

```
1 curl -X POST -d "key=fish" http://10.10.183.179/api/items | grep "flag"
```

- **Assembly Tie-In**: If the API returns a binary, disassemble:

```
1 curl -X POST -d "key=fish" http://10.10.183.179/api/items -o key.bin
2 objdump -d key.bin
```

7 Writing Your Own 'curl' Command

To craft a command: 1. **Choose Method**: Use '-X' (e.g., GET, POST). 2. **Set URL**: Target the endpoint (e.g., 'http://<IP>/api/items'). 3. **Add Options**: Include '-d' for data, '-H' for headers, '-o' for output. 4. **Handle Response**: Use '-i' or pipe to 'grep'. 5. **Test Variations**: Adjust payloads or methods.

Example Exercise Send a POST with JSON to get Pingu's key:

```
1 curl -X POST -H "Content-Type: application/json" -d '{"username": "pingu", "key": "fish123"}' http://10.10.183.179/api/items
```

8 Conclusion

With these techniques, you can use ‘curl’ to explore web servers, test APIs, and extract data in CTFs. Practice on ‘10.10.183.179’ and tweak your command based on responses. Master it, and you’ll unlock Pingu’s fish in no time!